trial. It was an odd charge, since many saw Gandhiji as the quintessential Hindu leader in Indian politics, but it is true that his Hinduism was not particularly religious in the conventional sense. He died with the name of Rama on his lips but there is no evidence that he ever believed in or worshipped a personal god. ('There is an indefinable mysterious power that pervades everything,' he wrote, implying faith in an impersonal, undefinable power: 'I don't regard God as a person.') Gandhi declared his faith in 'all that goes by the name of Hindu scriptures' but, as the scholar K. P. Shankaran points out, he 'immediately qualified it by saying that he also believed in all other religious texts in a similar way'.[18] He also took Hinduism's eclectic and wide-ranging texts and belief structures literally, making it clear that he retained the right to choose what tenets he believed in, to interpret what they taught him, and to reject anything in them that he could not agree with. His emphasis on the ethics of *satya* and *ahimsa*, elevating them above almost any of the other principles of Hinduism, was distinctive: 'Truth for me is God.'

Gandhi was more a reinterpreter of Hinduism than a reformer of it; by drawing from it to suit his beliefs and purposes, he redefined the traditional vocabulary of Hinduism without ever departing from it. He criticised many of the iniquitous social practices of Hinduism without denouncing the faith from which they had emerged, and unlike his contemporary Ambedkar, who denounced Hinduism's distortions and cruelties and eventually left the faith, Gandhi always tried to change it from within. According to K.P. Shankaran, Gandhi's rejection of the vocabulary of the European Enlightenment and modernity (for the reasons he had explained in his 1909 book, *Hind Swaraj)* forced him to fall back on a vocabulary that he was familiar with, that of the Vaishnava tradition of his parents. Gandhi's objective was to create an ethical Indian state founded on *ahimsa* and *satya*, non-violence and truth, principles he found in Advaita philosophy. The national motto of independent India—*Satyameva Jayate* (Truth Alone Triumphs)—is from the *Mundaka Upanishad*, chosen by Mahatma Gandhi as his guiding credo. His own translation of the Bhagavad Gita portrays the text as a philosophy of Anashakti Yoga, meant for votaries of *ahimsa*. Gandhiji took a text that had traditionally been seen as extolling war and action,